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The Third Force: How the DPM Could Overtake the NNP

The Democratic People's Movement won 1,189 votes in its first election, 21,378 behind the NNP, and beat it in just one seat. New parties have risen fast in Grenada before, but only after an older party fell apart. Here is the DPM's only realistic route to second place.

BY GREG HOSTEN

GRENADA, CARRIACOU AND PETITE MARTINIQUE, GRENADA

ST. GEORGE'S, GRENADA—Peter David launched the Democratic People's Movement at the Grenada Trade Centre on 16 November 2025, before a crowd that spilled outside the hall. He described a movement nurtured on street corners, built on the idea that a nation's strength lies in the participation of all rather than the power of a few. Less than a year later, the DPM fought its first general election.

> **"The DPM's path to second place runs through the NNP, not around it."**
> GREG HOSTEN

The result was sobering. The DPM contested nine seats and won 1,189 votes, 1.9 per cent of the total. Mr. David lost the Town of St. George, which he had first won in 2003. Yet in the Town the DPM did something no third party had done in Grenada in a generation: it pushed the NNP into third place. This volume asks whether the DPM could do that nationally, and become the second major party, by 2030/31.

THE SIZE OF THE GAP

The arithmetic is stark. The NNP won 22,567 votes. The DPM won 1,189. To draw level, the DPM would need to win nineteen times as many votes as it did in 2026, or the NNP would need to lose most of the support it kept even in the worst defeat of its history.

The DPM's vote was also concentrated in one place. Of its 1,189 votes, 730 came from the Town of St. George, 61 per cent of the total. Across its other eight seats it averaged 57 votes. Its best results outside the capital were 87 for Charmaine Gibbs in St. George South and 82 for its deputy leader, Arley Gill, in St. John. It did not stand at all in six constituencies, among them St. David and St. George North East, the second- and third-largest electorates in the country.

A realistic target makes the challenge plain. If the NDC wins around 35,000 votes in 2030/31 and turnout is similar, the DPM would need roughly 13,500 votes to finish ahead of the NNP, on the assumption that the two opposition parties split the rest. That is about eleven times what it won in 2026.

WHERE THE DPM IS ALREADY SECOND

In the Town of St. George, the DPM won 730 votes to the NNP's 536. It finished ahead of the NNP in 10 of the 12 polling divisions, including all five at the National Stadium, which together gave it 454 votes. Only in the two divisions at the Anglican Senior School did the NNP come second.

This was Mr. David's personal vote, built over twenty years as the Town's representative for two different parties. In 2022 he won the seat for the NNP with 1,329 votes. In 2026 he and the NNP's Troy Noel had 1,266 between them. Mr. David took more than half of that combined vote. The seat shows that the DPM can outpoll the NNP where it has a known, rooted candidate. It also shows how hard that is to copy elsewhere.

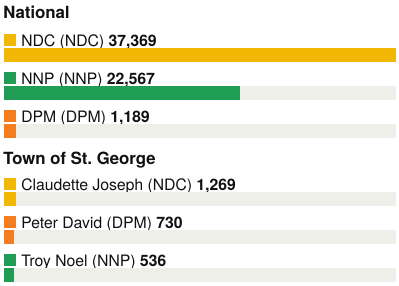
IT HAS HAPPENED BEFORE

Grenada's party system is younger and more fluid than it looks. The NNP itself was formed in August 1984 from a merger of smaller parties, and won the election that December. The NDC was founded on 18 October 1987 by George Brizan and Francis Alexis, in opposition to the NNP government. Within three years it was in office, having won 7 of the 15 seats in 1990 with 34.5 per cent of the vote.

The GULP, Sir Eric Gairy's party, dominated Grenadian politics for a generation. In 2026

NATIONAL VS TOWN OF ST. GEORGE

Votes by candidate, in party colours



21,378 votes

Gap between the NNP and the DPM, nationally, in 2026

BY THE NUMBERS

1,189
DPM votes in nine seats, 1.9 per cent of the total

730
DPM votes in the Town, ahead of the NNP's 536

10 of 12
Town polling divisions where the DPM beat the NNP

21,378
Votes between the NNP and the DPM nationally

it won 34 votes, all of them in St. John and St. George South East. Second place in Grenada is not permanent.

But the precedents have a common thread. The NNP and the NDC both rose by bringing together established politicians, sitting or former members with their own local followings, at a moment when an older party was divided or discredited. Neither grew one voter at a time from a single seat. If the DPM is to become the second party, it will be by the same route.

FIVE THINGS THE DPM WOULD HAVE TO DO

What follows is the strategy a third party in the DPM's position would need. Each step is measurable.

1. WIN THE TOWN

A party with no seat in parliament has no platform. The opposition's senators are appointed on the advice of the Leader of the Opposition, and with the NNP holding the only opposition seat, the DPM has neither a seat in the House nor one in the Senate. Winning the Town is therefore the DPM's first task. In 2026 it would have needed 540 more votes to overtake the NDC. Some of those could come from the 536 who voted NNP. The rest would have to come from the 1,687 registered voters in the Town who did not vote.

2. BECOME THE HOME FOR A REALIGNMENT

The DPM cannot overtake the NNP by organic growth alone. Its only realistic route is to attract established figures: former NNP candidates and branch officers who conclude, after a defeat of 14 seats to one, that the old party cannot win again. The NDC was built that way in 1987. Whether that happens depends less on the DPM than on how the NNP handles the next two years.

3. CONTEST EVERY SEAT, WITH CANDIDATES NAMED EARLY

A party that fields candidates in nine seats cannot finish second nationally. The DPM needs candidates in all 15 constituencies, named by 2028, with roots in the seats they contest. Every earlier volume of this series has shown the cost of late or parachuted candidates. A new party cannot afford them either.

4. SAY WHAT IT IS FOR

In 2026 the DPM's message centred on unity and participation, and on its leader. To become a major party, it needs a programme that voters can distinguish from both the NDC and the NNP: on the cost of living, on jobs for young people, and on how government should work. A party built around one person is limited by that person's constituency. A party built around an idea can travel.

5. BUILD BEYOND THE CAPITAL

The DPM's 459 votes outside the Town are a starting point, not a base. It needs branches and polling-division captains in the seats where it barely registered, beginning with the constituencies where its candidates did best, and a permanent presence in the six seats where it did not stand at all.

THE ROAD TO SEATS

Finishing second in votes is one ambition. Winning seats is another, and under first past the post it is the one that counts. There are two ways a third party can matter in parliament: by winning a handful of seats and holding the balance of power, or by winning eight and forming a government. The arithmetic of 2026 shows how far each is.

A RULE OF THUMB: 40 PER CENT

In a seat where three parties are competitive, a candidate can win with well under half the vote. As a working benchmark, this volume uses 40 per cent of the votes cast in 2026: enough to win a three-way contest in most circumstances, though not if one rival stays strong. The table on this page shows how many more votes the DPM would have needed in each constituency to reach that mark.

Only one seat is close. In the Town, 40 per cent was 1,016 votes, and the DPM had 730. It needed 286 more. In every other constituency it needed more than 1,000 extra votes, and in St. David almost 3,000. Across the eight easiest seats on that measure, the total is about 9,300 additional votes, roughly eight times what the party won nationally in 2026.

A MINORITY: HOLDING THE BALANCE

The more realistic ambition is a small bloc of seats. Grenada has had close parliaments before: the NDC formed a minority government in 1990 with 7 of the 15 seats, and the NNP governed from 2003 with a majority of one. If the NDC falls back and the NNP recovers, a result such as 7–6 with two seats for a third party would put the DPM in a position to decide who governs.

To get there, the DPM would need the Town plus one or two more seats. The evidence of this series is that the seats a small party can win are not the closest two-way marginals, where voters fear wasting a vote, but seats where a well-known local figure carries a personal vote. Vol. 7 showed Delma Thomas taking her vote with her when she changed parties in St. Andrew North West. A DPM minority strategy therefore depends on recruiting two or three people with that kind of following, sitting or former members, long-serving councillors or community leaders, and standing them in their home seats.

Holding the balance also requires a decision the DPM should make early and publicly: on what terms would it support a government? A party that says in advance what it would demand, such as campaign finance rules, constituency budgets or a specific policy programme, gives voters a reason to back it even if they do not expect it to govern.

A MAJORITY: THE EIGHT-SEAT MAP

A majority is a different order of task. It would mean the DPM rising from 1.9 per cent of the vote to something like 40 per cent nationally in one election. Neither of Grenada's two major parties did that on its own. The NNP won in 1984 as a merger of several parties. The NDC, three years after its founding, won 34.5 per cent in 1990 and formed a minority government.

On the 40 per cent measure, the DPM's easiest eight seats would be the Town, St. Patrick East, St. Mark, St. George North West, St. Patrick West, St. George South East, St. Andrew North West and St. Andrew South West. Even that list includes St. George North West, the NNP's last fortress, which shows how little room there is. A DPM majority could only come from a full realignment of the opposition, with most of the NNP's organisation and voters moving across, or from a merger. It cannot come from organic growth in one election cycle.

The honest conclusion is that the DPM's realistic seat target for 2030/31 is between one and three seats. A majority is a ten-year project at best, and it depends on what happens to the NNP.

THE FOUNDER'S QUESTION

Every party in Grenada eventually has to answer the same question: what happens after its founder? The NNP took two years too long to answer it, and paid for it in 2026. For the DPM the question arrives

early, because so much of what it won came from one man.

WILL MR. DAVID STAND AGAIN?

Mr. David was born in 1957. By 2030/31 he will be in his mid-seventies, and he has represented the Town in four parliaments since 2003. At the time of writing he has not said publicly whether he will lead the DPM into another one.

His personal standing is not in doubt. Before the election, polling attributed to Peter Wickham and discussed on a local radio programme gave him a rating of 6.7 against 5.3 for his NDC opponent. He still lost by 539 votes. A strong personal rating did not survive a national wave, and that is the DPM's dilemma in one result.

If Mr. David stands again, the DPM keeps its only proven vote-getter but risks remaining a one-seat, one-person party. If he does not, it loses the 730 votes that made up most of its total, unless someone else can inherit them. Either way, the decision cannot be left until the writ.

A SUCCESSOR, MENTORED IN TIME

The best example of a handover in this series is St. George North West. Dr. Keith Mitchell named Dr. Adrian Joseph ten months before polling day, campaigned beside him, and the NNP's share fell by only 2.4 points against a national swing of 10.3. Where the NNP left succession to chance, as in St. Mark and St. George South East, it fell much further.

If the DPM is to outlast its founder, Mr. David should name a successor, or a small leadership team, by the end of 2028. That leaves two years for the new leader to become known before an election that could come early. The successor should be given real work from the start: a national portfolio such as the cost of living, a target seat to build, and a place beside Mr. David in the Town, walking the Stadium divisions that gave the party 454 votes.

The test of a worthy successor is not loyalty. It is whether that person can win votes the founder cannot: younger voters, voters outside the capital, and NNP supporters who would never vote for Mr. David after the split of 2024. The party's deputy leader, Arley Gill, is the obvious first candidate, but he won 82 votes in St. John. Whoever is chosen will have to build a base of their own, and the founder's job is to make room for it.

FROM CANDIDATE TO CHAIRMAN

One option is for Mr. David to step off the ballot and into an executive role, such as party chairman or president, while a new political leader fronts the DPM in elections. Caribbean parties often use this arrangement. The NNP did: Dr. Mitchell gave up the leadership in 2024 and stayed on as party chairman until 2026.

The NNP's experience also shows the risk. The New Today reported that the new leader still relied on Dr. Mitchell for financial support and to draw supporters to meetings. A party with two centres of power invites the question of who is really in charge, and opponents will ask it loudly.

If Mr. David takes that route, the role should be written into the party's constitution and kept narrow: fundraising, the diaspora and mentoring, not candidate selection or the day-to-day message. He should set a public date for the handover, back his successor without qualification, and resist second-guessing in public. A founder who watches over a party can protect it. A founder who keeps steering it makes his successor look like a stand-in.

THE MONEY QUESTION

Grenada has no public funding for political parties, no limits on donations or spending, and no requirement for parties to disclose their finances, according to the International IDEA political finance database. Observer missions from the Organization of American States have repeatedly recommended campaign finance rules. In practice, every party depends on private money, and voters do not know who provides it.

That makes it impossible to say from the outside whether the DPM has the backing to last. What is clear is the scale of the task. Candidates in all 15 seats, offices that stay open between elections, and paid organisers for four years cost far more than a single campaign. The NNP's caretakers who were left without offices in 2025 show what happens to a party, even an established one, when the money runs thin.

The DPM took its campaign to Toronto and Brooklyn within weeks of its launch, and the diaspora is a natural base. A party that promises a new type of politics could also turn the absence of rules into an advantage: build a broad base of small donors and members' dues rather than a few large backers, and publish its accounts voluntarily. That would set it apart from both major parties. The clearest sign of whether the money is there will be simple: whether the DPM's offices are still open in 2028.

WHAT COULD STOP IT

The strongest argument against the DPM's rise is that the NNP's 22,567 voters did not leave in 2026. Many NNP supporters stayed at home, but those who voted stayed with their party, even in defeat. Everywhere except the Town, the NNP finished first or a clear second, and the DPM a distant third or not at all. Party loyalty in Grenada runs deep.

There is also the risk of being squeezed. Under first past the post, voters who want to remove a government tend to rally behind the strongest challenger. If the NNP recovers even part of its 2022 vote, the DPM could find itself where the GULP is today. And the DPM's best result depended on one candidate. If Mr. David does not stand again, the Town result may not be repeatable.

WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE NNP

The DPM's path to second place runs through the NNP, not around it. Only if the NNP fails to settle its leadership, loses more of its people and leaves its supporters without a reason to vote can the DPM become the opposition. In that sense this volume is a warning, not a forecast.

For the NNP, the lesson of the Town is the same as in Vol. 1: together, the two parties were three votes from winning. Apart, they finished second and third. Whether 2030/31 brings a reunited opposition, a realigned one or a still-divided one will decide more than which party comes second. It may decide whether the NDC wins a third term.

VOTES THE DPM WOULD NEED FOR 40 PER CENT, SEAT BY SEAT

Constituency	DPM 2026	40% of 2026 vote	Extra votes needed
Town of St. George	730	1,016	286
St. Patrick East	68	1,136	1,068
St. Mark	—	1,126	1,126
St. George North West	—	1,172	1,172
St. Patrick West	53	1,353	1,300
St. George South East	66	1,484	1,418
St. Andrew North West	39	1,495	1,456
St. Andrew South West	—	1,505	1,505
Carriacou and Petite Martinique	—	1,523	1,523
St. Andrew South East	19	1,552	1,533
St. Andrew North East	45	1,627	1,582
St. John	82	1,845	1,763
St. George North East	—	2,058	2,058
St. George South	87	2,631	2,544
St. David	—	2,982	2,982

40 per cent of valid votes cast in 2026, a rough benchmark for winning a three-way contest. — : the DPM did not stand. The eight easiest seats need about 9,300 extra votes in total. 2026 figures provisional.

THE DPM'S FIRST ELECTION, SEAT BY SEAT

Constituency	Candidate	Votes	Share	Place
Town of St. George	Peter David	730	28.6%	2nd
St. George South	Charmaine Gibbs	87	1.3%	3rd
St. John	Arley Gill	82	1.8%	3rd
St. Patrick East	Dishon Edwards	68	2.4%	3rd
St. George South East	Stanford Simon	66	1.8%	3rd
St. Patrick West	Andy Best	53	1.6%	3rd
St. Andrew North East	Pamela Williams	45	1.1%	3rd
St. Andrew North West	Olvine Holas	39	1.0%	3rd
St. Andrew South East	Shirley McQueen	19	0.5%	3rd
Total, nine seats		1,189	1.9%	

Share of ballots cast in the constituency. The DPM did not contest St. George North West, St. George North East, St. Andrew South West, St. David, St. Mark or Carriacou and Petite Martinique. 2026 figures provisional.

WHAT IT MEANS FOR 2030/31

1. The DPM trails the NNP by 21,378 votes and needs about eleven times its 2026 total.
2. 61 per cent of the DPM vote came from one seat.
3. In the Town it beat the NNP in 10 of 12 polling divisions.
4. New parties have become major ones in Grenada, but only through realignment.
5. Without a seat, the DPM has no platform in parliament: the Town comes first.
6. A party in nine seats cannot finish second: it needs all 15.
7. First past the post squeezes third parties when voters want change.
8. Realistic seat target for 2030/31: one to three, enough to hold the balance.
9. A majority needs a realignment or merger, not one cycle of growth.
10. Mr. David should name and mentor a successor by the end of 2028.
11. If he moves to an executive role, keep it narrow and set a handover date.
12. No public funding and no disclosure rules: publish accounts and build small donors.
13. For the NNP: reunited, the opposition was three votes from winning the Town.

Sources: Parliamentary Elections Office live results, live.elections.gd (2026, provisional; all constituencies and polling divisions read 7 and 9 Nov 2026); Wikipedia (2022 and 2026 general elections; National Democratic Congress; New National Party; Peter David); Caribbean National Weekly and Caribbean Today (DPM launch, Nov 2025); NOW Grenada (DPM executive and congress, Mar 2026); Caribbean Times / CMC (DPM congress, 22 Mar 2026); Wee FM (DPM congress and North America meetings); Mikey Live (DPM meeting and polling remarks, Oct 2026); OneNews St. Vincent (leaders' debate, Oct 2026); The New Today (DPM launch, Nov 2025; editorial on the NNP leadership); Caribbean National Weekly (NNP convention, Jun 2026); International IDEA Political Finance Database (Grenada); Nation News (OAS mission on campaign finance); The Rio Times (DPM slate, Oct 2026; results, 6 Nov 2026); Jamaica Gleaner / CMC (results, 6 Nov 2026). Shares, gaps and targets computed by the author from the published counts. Analysis by Greg Hosten, Vol. 18 of a weekly constituency series. Written in the style of a newspaper report; not a publication of any news organisation.